

The State of Out-of-district Political Donations in Canada*

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Federal political representation in Canada is fundamentally geographical; one Members of Parliament (MP) represents one electoral district. Despite this structural expectation, Canadians can donate to a host of political entities regardless of proximity, questioning the integrity of this representational structure. [Using publically-disclosed contribution data made available by Elections Canada between 2015 and 2024], we provide the first descriptive analysis of the extent, timing, and flow patterns of out-of-district donations in Canada. We payed special attention to data characteristics that have been addressed by already-existing research on this topic abroad. We discover [...]. These and other findings help to [...], and more generally in a critical assessment of effective representation in a Westminster-style parliamentary democracy.

Keywords: Canadian politics; out-of-district donations; surrogate representation; political participation; political geography

1 Introduction

2 Literature Review

2.1 Political Donation, Participation, and Representation

In Canada and many other Western democratic nations, federal representation is fundamentally geographical: a Member of Parliament (MP) supposedly represents the aggregate views of their

*Code and data are available at: <https://github.com/bennypk1/geolocating-political-donations>.

constituents, that is, everyone who lives within the boundaries of their riding. By voting during a general election, the citizens of a given electoral district increase the likelihood that their incumbent MP votes, acts, looks, and thinks how they want them to. Provided that (1) the division of people into ridings efficiently clusters like-minded Canadians, and (2) each Canadian participates equally (for example, through their one vote), we should expect a high degree of congruence between what a legislator does, and what their constituents want, achieving a truly representative democracy ([Bednar and Gerber 2011](#)).

Beyond voting, individual citizens often seek to increase their local representation by volunteering at a local electoral district association (EDA), advocating for their preferred party online, or financially supporting a candidate’s campaign ([Bednar and Gerber 2011](#); [Baker 2016](#); [Garnett 2024](#)). Since these necessitate more resources (e.g. time, effort, or money), indicate greater political interest, and often have larger impacts on electoral outcomes relative to voting, political scientists classically argue that these constitute “higher forms” of political participation ([Bednar and Gerber 2011](#)).

Among these, donations stand out as a useful unit for (1) understanding the motivations behind political participation and (2) assessing whether higher forms of political participation distort the dyadic relationship between constituents and their MP. Here, we discuss two reasons why. First, donations are spatiotemporally unconstrained, telling us exactly when and where citizens seek representation ([Gimpel et al. 2008](#); [Garnett 2024](#)). While the voter can only seek representation within their district and during an election cycle, the donor can legally contribute to various political entities, whenever, and as often as they want, subject to annual and per-election limits ([Gimpel et al. 2008](#); [Elections Canada 2026a](#)). Second, donations are the primary means by which individuals extend their representation beyond district borders. Enabled by modern digital communication, individuals are increasingly motivated to finance national parties, or non-local candidates, in an attempt to be represented on ideological, partisan, or identity-based grounds ([Gimpel et al. 2008](#)). For example, a Green-party partisan may realize their local candidate will lose, and are perfectly content funding another Green candidate in a closer race somewhere else. Similarly, a Black candidate may appeal to Black donors across the country seeking identity-based representation. Given that individual donors are the presently largest source of campaign funding ([Carmichael and Howe 2014](#); [Garnett 2024](#)), high rates of out-of-district donation are of particular concern, since they risk shifting the effective representational structure away from one-Legislator-one-district and towards

one-Legislator-one-donor base.

2.2 Political Donations in the Canadian Context: What has been done

Much research has been done to determine the socio-demographic characteristics of donors and candidates in Canada. Most notably, Garnett analyzed candidate-bound donations during the 2015, 2019, and 2021 general elections, finding that donors are much more likely to originate from older, wealthier, and better-educated districts ([Carmichael and Howe 2014](#); [Garnett 2024](#)). The gender gap in giving has recieved particular attention, likely given the broader context of the established gender gap in political participation McMahon et al. ([2023](#)). From 2004 to 2015, overall federal donation amounts have increased, particularly in Western Canada, and among Conservative political entities ([McMahon and Wolfe 2015](#)). The COVID-19 pandemic saw overall reduced political participation during it's first year ([McMahon et al. 2023](#)).

Garnett et al. propose that donors in Canada donate for two reasons: political (i.e. for representational gain) and transactional (i.e. a favour for a friend, or a willingness to be seen). They find that political motivations for giving are more prevalent overall, but especially among older and affluent donors who contributed larger sums. Transactional donations were more likely at the local level, while political donations were more likely at the national level ([Garnett et al. 2022](#)).

When analyzing donor-recipient relationships, Canadian research has found that donors tend to donate more to candidates that they share aspects of their identity with ([Tolley et al. 2022](#); [Besco and Tolley 2022](#)). Tolley et al. found that women donors are more likely to donate to women candidates ([Tolley et al. 2022](#)), and Besco & Tolley found high rates of co-ethnic donation, particularly among South Asian donors ([Besco and Tolley 2022](#)). More generally, South Asian political participation appears to be particularly heightened in Canada, relative to other ethnocultural groups ([Garnett 2024](#)). Together with previous findings on donor motivation, these results the hypothesis that out-of-district donors in Canada are likely socially motivated, seeking individual-based representation.

Some work has also been done assessing the impacts of large amounts of political donation on representation. Among incumbent Legislators, voting behaviour is seemingly independent of the composition of their donor base ([Peoples and Gortari 2008](#)). However, an older study

found that local campaign donations during the 1993 and 1997 elections meaningfully affected the amount of votes a candidate receives (Eagles 2004).

Finally, we describe some unique aspects of Canadian political engagement, and particularly those that distinguish Canada from the U.S., where the large majority of work on out-of-district donations has been done. These differences will help us formulate hypotheses to guide our analysis. Most notably, party loyalty in Canada is weak ; it is estimated that only around 2% of Canadians are registered members of any political party (Garnett et al. 2022), compared with around 40% in the U.S (USAFacts 2026). This has been attributed to many things, including the argument that Canada’s multi-party system de-emphasizes partisan membership (Carty 2002). This system also invites more ephemeral loyalties, based on specific policies or identities, and not broad-scope ideological affiliation. Many (historically) large parties in Canada were founded for specific reasons, for example the Bloc Quebecois, Reform Party, and Green Party, which cater(ed) to a very specific audience. High rates of immigration may have increase emphasis on cutural and not political belonging (Carty 2002; Besco and Tolley 2022).

2.3 American Out-of-District Donations to U.S. House Representatives

We were unable to find a rigorous treatment of out-of-district donations during Canadian federal elections. By contrast, American scholars have explicitly addressed out-of-district donations and their impacts on legislative representation, catalyzed primarily by Gimpel et al.’s extensive treatment of individual out-of-district donations during 4 Congressional elections from 1994 – 2004 (Gimpel et al. 2008). They propose the existence of “donor districts” ; a small set of older, wealthy, well-educated, and urban districts wherein a large majority of out-of-district donations originate, destined to Republican and Democrat candidates alike (Gimpel et al. 2008; Bramlett et al. 2011). We should notice that these socio-economic factors are the same drivers of donor output in general across North America (Gimpel et al. 2006; Garnett 2024). Over this time period, they also observed an increase in the proportion of non-local donations received by the average candidate, from around 50% in 1994 to nearly 70% in 2004 (Gimpel et al. 2008). More recent studies suggest that this and similar trends have continued past 2004 (Bramlett et al. 2011; Baker 2016; Canes-Wrone and Miller 2022). Driven by the observation that the “closeness” of local races strongly predicted which districts received these non-local donations, Gimpel et al. argue that gaining a partisan advantage (and not seeking ideological

or identity-based representation) is the primary motivation behind non-local donations ([Gimpel et al. 2008](#)).

Follow-up American research has found that Out-of-district campaign contributions affects the voting behaviour of Congressional representatives, thereby distorting the supposedly-dyadic relationship between a representative and their district. A study of the 2006-2010 Congressional elections revealed that the average House representative becomes less responsive to their constituencies’ ideological preferences with increased out-of-district public funding ([Baker 2016](#)). Canes-Wrone & Miller further explore the 2006-2016 Congressional elections to show that House voting behaviour is indeed associated with the preferences of their nation donor base ([Canes-Wrone and Miller 2022](#)), contrasted against research finding that political action committees (U.S. equivalents to EDAs) do not affect roll call behaviour ([Ansolabehere et al. 2003](#)). Another study on Senatorial elections emphasizes the rivalrous relationship between constituents and out-of-district donors, experimentally showing that constituents who learned about outside donation expected their Senators to be less loyal to local interests ([Nathan et al. 2025](#)). More generally, longitudinal analyses of out-of-state (and therefore out-of-district donations) during Senate elections echo many House findings ([Sievert and Mathiasen 2023](#); [Jacobs and Imboywa 2024](#); [Keena 2024](#)).

To an even greater extent than in Canada, individual donors are the primary source of funding for both U.S. campaigns and U.S. congressmen ([Gimpel et al. 2008](#); [Baker 2016](#)). This fact, paired with the many known effects of out-of-district donors on campaigns and representatives discussed above paint the picture that representatives “represent” little more than the whims of their national donor base.

3 Data

3.1 Data Overview

The data used in this paper was sourced primarily from Election Canada’s Open Data website ([Elections Canada 2025a](#)). Their (NAME OF SET) represents all donations made by individuals to registered federal political entities since January 2004 ([Elections Canada 2025a](#)). Since that start date, the *Canada Elections Act* has required that all contributions (monetary or otherwise) valued at over \$20 be recorded by the recipient and shared with (WHO?) ([Elections Canada](#)

2026e). Contributors associated with contributions valued at over \$200 [representing the large majority of contributions ; CITATION] must have their full name and address recorded as well (Elections Canada 2026e).

For donations valued at over \$200, the donor’s name, location (including postal code), as well as the recipient’s name, FED (if applicable), party (if applicable), type (e.g. National party, Candidate, etc.). To assess whether or not a donation was out-of-district, the publically available donor postal codes were matched with their corresponding FED using Statistics Canada’s Postal Code Conversion Files. To simplify our cleaning and analysis, we restricted our focus to only contributions made within the 2013 representational order, corresponding to the period between Oct 2nd, 2015 and Apr 22nd, 2024 (Elections Canada 2025b). This is the largest such order present in the full dataset, notably capturing X% of total recorded contributions, and 3 general election periods [42nd, 43rd, and 44th respectively ; the same ones as Garnett (2024), allowing for direct comparison with her work]. Our data was further augmented with CENSUS DATA ... Our cleaning procedure is described in full in Appendix X.

Table 1: First 4 Rows of Cleaned Individual Donations Data (Subset of Columns).

Donor Name	Donor District	Recipient Name	Amount
Robert McBain	Beaches–East York	Hedy Fry	500
Maria Minna	Beaches–East York	Hedy Fry	500
Hedy Fry	Vancouver Granville	Hedy Fry	1500
David Bronfman	Eglinton–Lawrence	Maxime Bernier	20

Table 2: First 4 Rows of Cleaned District Flows Data (Subset of Columns)

Sending District	Receiving District	Donations (count)	Donations (amount)
Abbotsford	Abbotsford	355	150135
Abbotsford	Banff–Airdrie	1	1000
Abbotsford	Burnaby North–Seymour	2	3000
Abbotsford	Burnaby South	1	1000

Our cleaning produced two related datasets that were used for different parts of the analysis. The first represented all individual contributions made during our focal period, to any recipient.

Table 1 displays the first few rows and columns of this data. This dataset was used to document preliminary findings, and understand how out-of-district donations relate to in-district donations. The second is a subset of the first, and includes only donations whose recipients are local political entities (Candidates, Nomination Contestants, and EDAs). This second dataset was subsequently wrangled such that each row represented a donor-recipient district pair, allowing us to effectively track interdistrict flows of donations at various points in time and space. Table 2 displays the first few rows and columns of this data. National entities (Leadership Contestants and Registered Parties) were necessarily excluded from this data since they cannot be tied to any one local FED.

3.2 Individual Donations Data Summary

Below we present a few longitudinal visualizations of the first dataset. We start with the disclaimer that all types of donations occurred at much higher rates in December compared to other months, regardless of year, recipient type, party affiliation, etc. This is likely a clerical error (ELABORATE). This did not impact our analysis (CHECK THIS WHEN FLOW ANALYSIS IS CARRIED OUT), however December donations in all Figures presented below were imputed using their neighboring November and January values, and their recorded monetary amounts were redistributed accross their associated years so that nothing was lost. This served to reduce visual clutter from large, phantom peaks at the end of each year.

Although Figures below only display trends in Monthly donation sums, donation counts were largely identical, and are shown in Appendix X.

Figure 1 and Figure 2 display the timeline of donatios to Leadership Contestants and National (i.e. Registered) parties. The 6 main peaks in the graph clearly correspond to general election periods (peaks followed immediately by grey lines) and Conservative party leadership campaigns (blue-tipped peaks in Figure 1). Interestingly, elections and leadership contests result in relatively similar amounts of donations to national political entites, with the notable exception of the 2022 Conservative leadership race, won by current Opposition Leader Pierre Poilievre. Overall, donations to national entities seem to have increased during this period, following the increasing trend observed from 2004 - 2015 by McMahon and Wolfe (McMahon and Wolfe 2015), and particularly starying in 2022, a recent phenomenon driven primarily by increased donations to the Conservative and Liberal parties (Figure 2). Although National Parties are somewhat

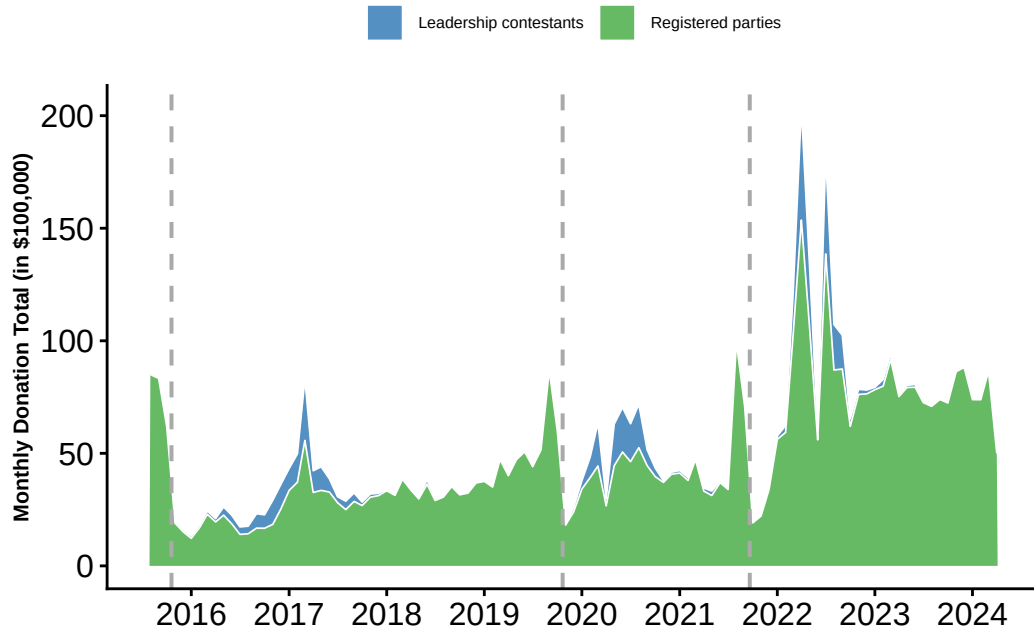


Figure 1: Federal Political Donations to National Entities (Oct 2015 - Apr 2024), Subsetted by Entity. Dashed vertical lines indicate general election dates for the 42nd, 43rd, and 44th general elections respectively.

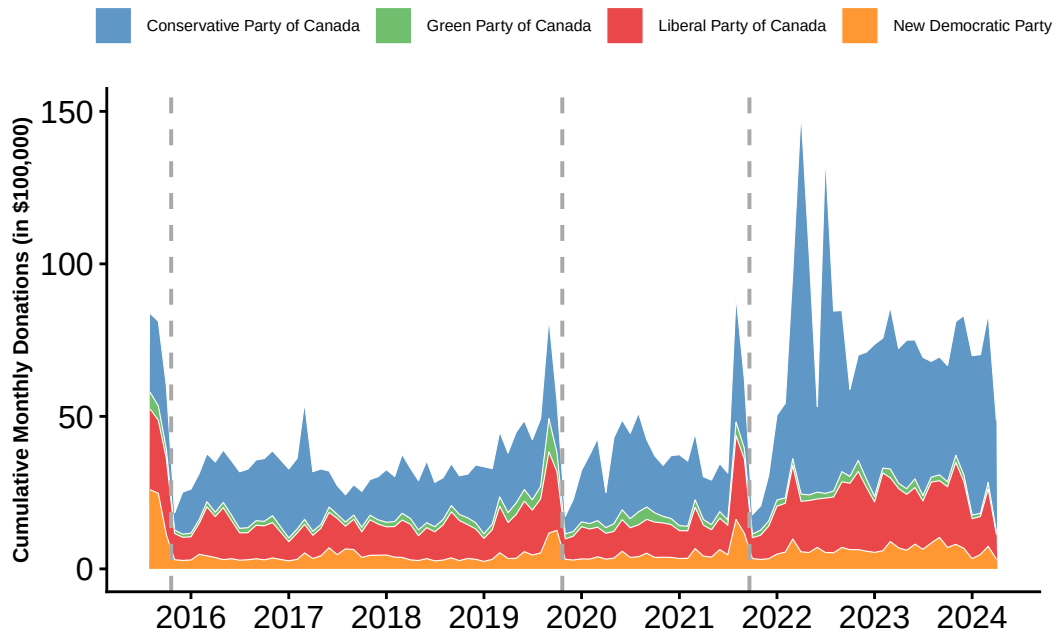


Figure 2: Federal Political Donations to National Entities (Oct 2015 - Apr 2024), Subsetted by Party. Only data from top 4 parties is shown. Dashed vertical lines indicate general election dates for the 42nd, 43rd, and 44th general elections respectively.

out of scope when analyzing out-of-district donations, understanding their trends provides helpful context, especially since they represent the large majority ($\sim 90\%$) of donations in our dataset.

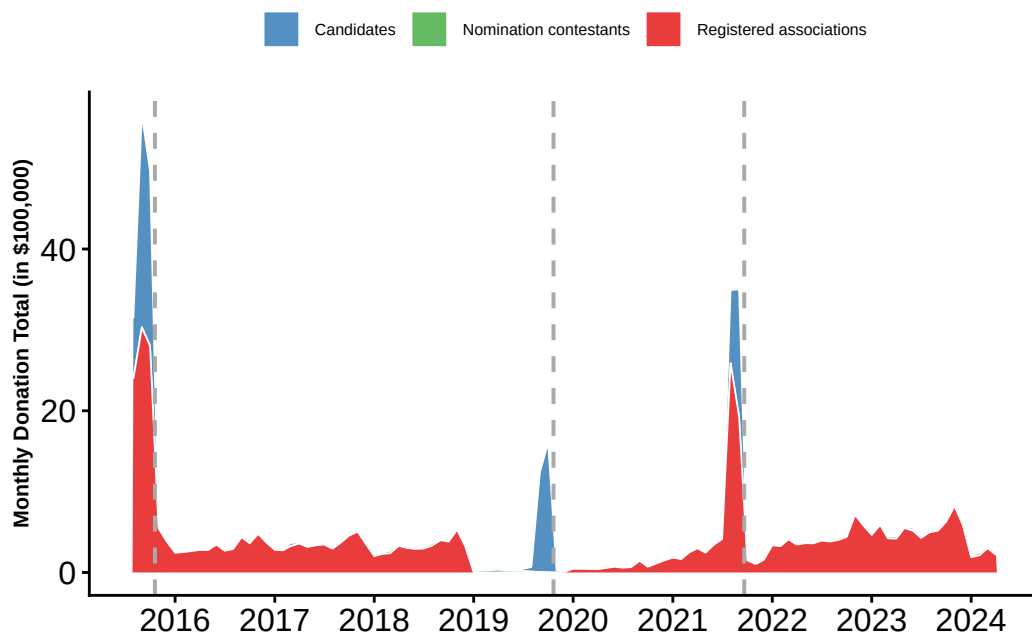


Figure 3: In-District Donations to Local Political Entities (Oct 2015 - Apr 2024), Subsetted by Entity. Dashed vertical lines indicate general election dates for the 42nd, 43rd, and 44th general elections respectively.

Figure 3, Figure 4, Figure 6, and Figure 5 display various subsets of donations to Local Political Entities (i.e. EDAs, Candidates, and Registered Associations). Figure 3 and Figure 6 showcase in-district local donations, broken down by entity and party respectively. Figure 4 and Figure 5 show the same breakdowns but for out-of-district local donations (the reader should note that donations to National political bodies cannot be “in-district” or “out-of-district”, hence why it is not considered at that level). Like with Figures Figure 1 and Figure 2, donations to EDAs and Candidates peak during general election periods. Nomination Contestants are relatively scarce, even though many nomination capmaigns occured in Canada during this period (CITATION). This is likely because these contests recieve little media coverage, and occur entirely among local by the party (Pruysers and Cross 2016). This is unlike Leadership contests, which receive widespread national media coverage, at least among the largest parties (CITATION), whichm may explain why they appear clearly in Figure 1. Donations to Candidates are restricted to elections (HOWEVER THIS MAY BE AN ISSUE WITH THE DATA, TO BE

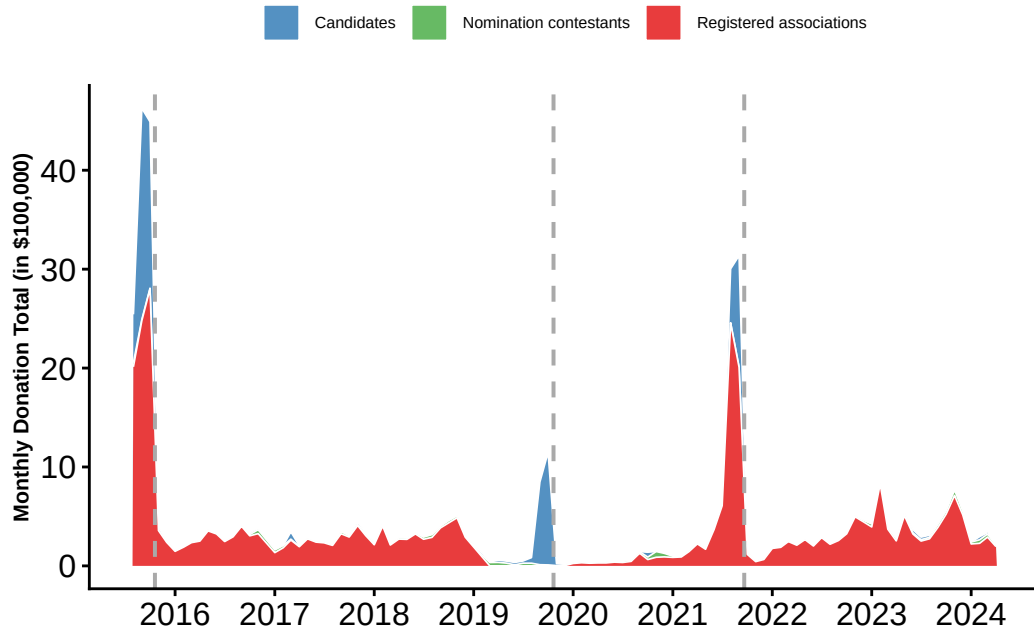


Figure 4: Out-of-District Donations to Local Political Entities (Oct 2015 - Apr 2024), Subsetted by Entity. Dashed vertical lines indicate general election dates for the 42nd, 43rd, and 44th general elections respectively.

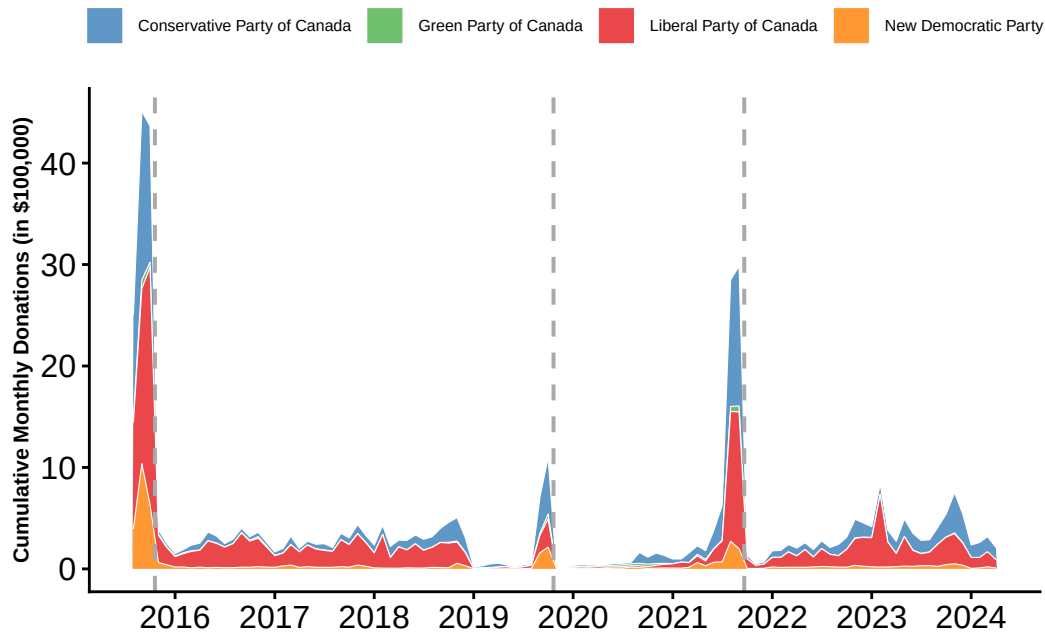


Figure 5: Out-of-District Donations to Local Political Entities (Oct 2015 - Apr 2024), Subsetted by Party. Only data from top 4 parties is shown. Dashed vertical lines indicate general election dates for the 42nd, 43rd, and 44th general elections respectively.

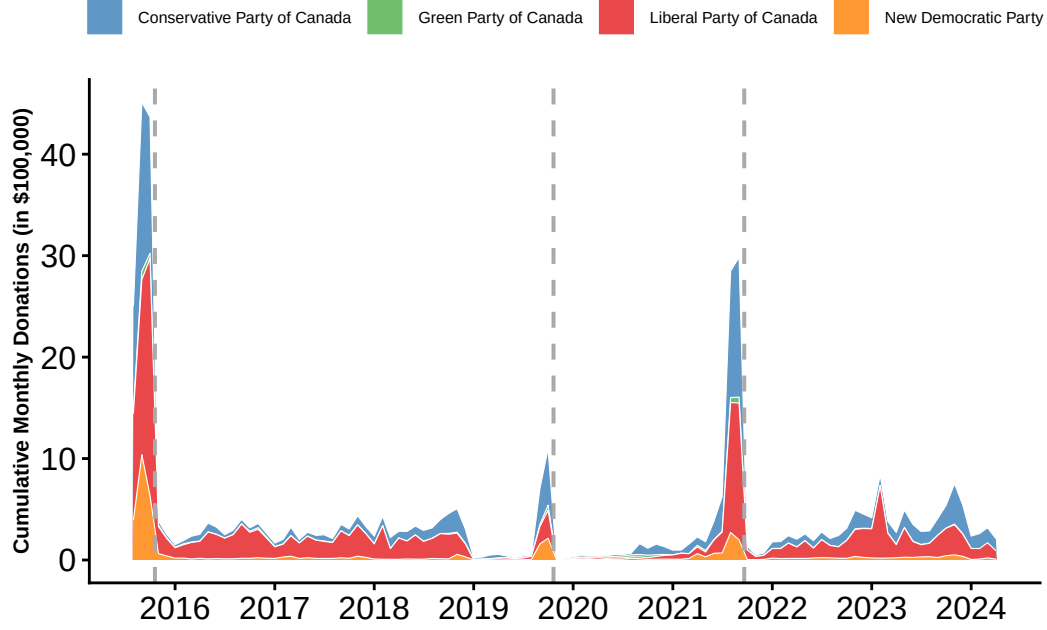


Figure 6: In-District Donations to Local Political Entities (Oct 2015 - Apr 2024), Subsetted by Party. Only data from top 4 parties is shown. Dashed vertical lines indicate general election dates for the 42nd, 43rd, and 44th general elections respectively.

INVESTIGATED MORE THOROUGHLY). Most notably, the longitudinal distribution of in and out-of-district donations is seemingly identical, both during and outside of general elections.

Table 3: Summary Statistics for Donations given outside election cycles.

Entity	Mean Annual Amount	Mean Annual Count	Prop OOD Amount	Prop OOD Count
Registered parties	43601160	344577.7	NA	NA
Registered associations	5189647	34876.9	0.454051	0.2628961

Table 4: Summary Statistics for Donations given within election cycles.

Entity	Mean Cycle Amount	Mean Annual Count	Prop OOD Amount	Prop OOD Count
Registered parties	46983815	306903	NA	NA
Registered associations	21177221	53880	0.4677858	0.3547513
Candidates	18560202	31120	0.4232764	0.3907455

Table 5: Donations in and out of election cycles by party, for the top 4 Parties.

Party	Mean Annual Amount	In-Cycle Prop
Conservative Party of Canada	32662835	0.0995874
Liberal Party of Canada	17854750	0.1583345
New Democratic Party	6876571	0.2551378
Green Party of Canada	2505790	0.1650749

Table 3, and Table 4, and Table 5 showcase some key annual summary statistics. Accross parties, donations are mainly accumulated outside of election capmaigns (see Table 5) ; around 10-15% of donor-sourced funds among the top 4 Parties, with the notable exception of the NDP at 25%. However, roughly 45% of donor-sourced funds to local entites (i.e. EDAs and Candidates) orginated from outside their districts, both in and out of election cycles. The identical and stagnant longitudinal distribution between in and ou-of donors illustrated in Figures Figure 4 shows that this proportion is roughly constant over time, unlike the increasing OOD proportion of donations in the U.S. over a similar time period (CITATION). In all cases, the count proportions were smaller than the amount proportions. This means that, on average, out-of-district and out-of-cycle donors are contributing larger amounts.

3.3 District Flows Data Summary

#TODO

A Background on Federal Donation Limits

The Canadian Elections Act imposes contribution limits on the following registered, federal political entities (see a full list of definitions at [Elections Canada 2026c](#)): political parties, local electoral district associations (EDAs), candidates, party nomination contestants, and party leadership contestants ([Elections Canada 2026a](#)). Regulated expenses for any of the entities themselves cannot exceed specific values (determined on an annual basis, different for each riding. Leadership contestants are a notable exception, with no campaign spending limits. See Elections Canada ([2026b](#))). Notably, registered third parties are not contribution-limited by the Act ([Elections Canada 2026d](#)). However, expenses relating to their activities are capped on a per-riding basis, similar to other political entities ([Elections Canada 2026b](#))

Only Canadian citizens or permanent residents can make contributions ([Elections Canada 2026e](#)). Any donor who contributed \$20 or more to any of the five federal political entities listed above must have their name recorded (but not reported to Elections Canada ; Elections Canada ([2026e](#))). Donors with contributions exceeding \$200 must also have their names and addresses recorded and reported to Elections Canada ([Elections Canada 2026e](#)). Cash donations above \$20 are prohibited ([Elections Canada 2026e](#)).

Table A1: 2026 Annual Limits on Individual Contributions, Loans, and Loan Guarantees (adapted from Elections Canada website).

Political Entity	2026 Annual Limit (CAD)
To each registered national party	1,775
In total, to all EDAs, nomination contestants, and candidates (for each registered party)	1,775
In total, to each independent or non-affiliated candidate	1,775

Table A2: 2026 Special Cases for Politicians

Politician	Own-Campaign Contribution Limit
Nomination Contestant	2,775
Candidate	5,000

Politician	Own-Campaign Contribution Limit
Leadership Contestant	25,000

Other Info to put somewhere:

- Electoral district boundaries are subject to change every 10 years, as required by the Constitution of Canada ([Elections Canada 2025b](#)).
- Increases by \$25 each year

B Source to IJF

The raw donations dataset is from Elections Canada’s “Open data on contributions” page (see Elections Canada ([2025a](#))), and was accessed for this study on May 5, 2026. This dataset represents all contribution reports filed by registered political entities (see Appendix A) from January 2004 to present ([Elections Canada 2025a](#)). This is the exact data the IJF starts with.

Table B1 shows how each source column is cleaned and mapped by the IJF. Source data had 10,095,198 entries, while IJF had 8,095,810 entries.

IJF appended extra archived data from the site (see [Elections Canada 2025a](#)), covering donations to political entities and candidates from 1993 - 2004. These do not matter for our analysis, and were discarded.

In the raw data, 31,873 rows (0.3% of the total data) is not from Individual donors (Buisnesses, Corporations, Trade, Associations, Government, Unincorporated). These can immediately be ignored.

C IJF to Clean

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